



GOLF RULES EDUCATION



GOLF RULES EDUCATION: HOW TO TALK TO THE AI RULES ASSISTANT

This AI Official operates on absolute, literal logic. To get an instant, 100% accurate penalty calculation on the course, you must format your story around these three strict rules:

1. Give an Accurate Timeline (Or the AI will assume one)

- Walk through your actions step-by-step in the exact chronological order they happened.
- If a conversation took place between two infractions, explicitly state it (e.g., "After that conversation, I then..."). If you omit the order, the AI will guess the sequence.

2. Remove Irrelevant Information (Or the AI will get confused)

- Stick strictly to the physical facts: where the ball was, what it touched, what was said, and what action was taken.
- Do not include narrative filler like how bad the shot was, the weather, or unrelated holes, as extra text dilutes the AI's rule-matching precision.

3. Provide Complete Information (Or the AI will guess)

- The AI cannot see your lie. You must explicitly state missing variables such as:
 - Ball intent, mutual player agreements, exact locations (e.g., "in a bunker" vs. "on the green").
 - Whether a ball was replaced or played as it lay.
 - Differentiate between stroke play and matchplay.

Without these details, the engine is forced to fill in the blanks.

Understanding the AI Agent's Limitations

This assistant is powered by a Large Language Model (LLM). While it knows the R&A Rules of Golf perfectly, it has four major technical habits and limitations you must account for:

1. **It tries to be too helpful, too fast:** The AI Agent wants to give you an immediate answer. If you dump a massive story on it all at once, it may rush to a conclusion and focus on the wrong penalty.
2. **Keep your sequence clear:** The AI Agent evaluates timelines in exact chronological order. To resolve multi-step disputes, simply state what happened first, what happened second, and let its internal logic filters map the root cause.
3. **The Agent assumes context if you are not precise:** You must explicitly differentiate between 'Stroke Play' and 'Match Play' because rules and penalties differ. If you are not explicit, the AI Agent automatically assumes 'General Play'.
4. **It is highly vulnerable to format-blending ("Fluff Phrasing"):** Injecting hypothetical format comparisons (e.g., "*acting as though it is a four-ball competition*") creates a mathematical "gravity well" in the agent's attention heads. This causes it to pull in unrelated rules, ignore physical clarifications, and hallucinate blanket penalties. Keep the active format pure.
5. **It is easily misled by rule numbers:** The AI Agent is designed to be highly accommodating and will assume you know what you are talking about. If you casually throw out an incorrect or



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guessed rule number (e.g., "Can I do X under Rule 16?"), the agent's semantic engine anchors heavily to that specific container. It may accidentally bypass crucial definitions or exceptions sitting in other sections just to answer your specific rule query as it just wants to agree with you.

🔧 How to Break Down Complex Questions

Rule 1: Always Speak in the First Person ("I" or "My") — To guarantee maximum retrieval accuracy from the rules database, always phrase your question as if it happened directly to you (e.g., 'I picked up my ball-marker...'). Avoid abstract textbook wording like 'What happens if a player mistakenly lifts...'

Rule 2: State Physical Actions Only

Tell the agent exactly what the players physically did, not what they were thinking or what format they were imagining.

- **✗ Don't say:** "We thought we were playing four-ball, so my partner picked up my ball..."
- **Do say:** "Foursomes match. Partner lifted player's ball without authorization."

Rule 3: Deconstruct the Timeline

Break dense, multi-step arguments into quick, back-and-forth conversational steps instead of one massive paragraph.

- **✗ Don't say:** "My ball was on the cart path, so I dropped it, but my stance was still on it, so I re-dropped, then hit it into a ditch where I wanted unplayable relief..."
- **Do say:** Deliver your scenario in a quick milestone sequence. Ask about the cart path drop first. Wait for the AI to answer. Then ask about the penalty area ditch.

Break dense, multi-step arguments into a clear chronological sequence. The AI Agent evaluates scenarios in exact linear order.

If multiple separate breaches happened, or if a conversation or warning interrupted your actions, you must explicitly flag that gap to separate the events. The machine is heavily pattern-matched to collapse overlapping rules if you present them as one fluid sentence. Force a timeline checkpoint by naturally using explicit transition phrases such as:

- "I did X. My partner stopped me, and after that conversation, I did Y..."
- "Next, as a separate step, I..."
- "First this happened, and then after that..."

Using clear time-anchors forces the agent's natural logic filters to pause, isolate independent phases, recognize conversational "Intervening Events," and calculate your exact score perfectly!

Rule 4: Strip Out Intent

The rules judge the physical result. Do not ask the AI to judge a player's state of mind unless the rule explicitly commands an intent check.



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- **✗ Don't say:** "He didn't mean to press the sprinkler head down; he just stepped on it heavily..."
- **Do say:** "Player stepped on and depressed a sprinkler head on their line of play."

Rule 5: Focus on Nouns, Not Rule Numbers

If you do not know the exact rule number for a fact, **do not guess or include one**. Let the agent find the rule for you. Phrasing a question with a forced rule number anchors the search engine and can deflect the agent into giving a wrong answer.

- **✗ Don't say:** *"I have interference from a pipe, can I take free relief under Rule 16.1?"*
- **✓ Do say:** *"My ball is right next to a patch of raised turf caused by an underground pipe. The bulge completely messes up my swing. Am I allowed free relief?"*

● How to Stop the Agent Mid-Speech

Because the AI is designed to be highly helpful, it will occasionally launch into a long explanation of a ruling (p. 1). If you hear it start down the wrong path, do not wait for it to finish speaking (p. 1).

You can interrupt and instantly cut off the AI by saying these sharp, repetitive commands directly into your microphone (p. 2):

- 🗣️ **"Stop, stop, stop!"**
- 🗣️ **"Wait, wait, wait!"**

Saying these words three or more times quickly triggers the agent's interruption filters, completely clears its speech buffer, and opens the microphone back up so you can redirect its logic or supply a specific rule number.

🔍 How to Force the Agent to Review a Wrong Answer

If the agent gives an incorrect answer, it is almost always because a confidently stated rule number or an abstract phrase over-anchored its attention heads. The agent will search out the truth for you, but you must occasionally break its confirmation bias if you led it down the wrong path.

If the AI gives you a ruling that you know is wrong, do not argue with it or repeat the same story. Repeating the story will just cause the AI to repeat its mistake.

Instead, use your interruption words ("**Wait, wait, wait!**"), break its loop, and force it to audit itself by guiding it toward the specific concept or rule number:

- **If you don't know the rule number**, simply feed the agent the core keywords of the situation:
 - *"Stop, stop, stop. Please review that based on my opponent giving me the wrong score information first."*
 - *"Wait, look at the timeline. Does my opponent's initial mistake cancel out my ball-handling error?"*



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- *"Re-evaluate that as a standalone event. I only lifted my marker because of the information my opponent gave me)."*
- **If you happen to know the exact rule number**, state it directly to bypass all assumptions:
 - *"Stop, stop, stop. Please review that under Rule 3.2d regarding giving wrong score information in match play)."*
 - *"Wait, please look directly at Rule 14.1."*

By naming a specific keyword concept or using the phrase "Review under Rule (X)", you trigger the AI's internal logic gates, forcing it to drop its assumptions and look directly at its uploaded R&A data.



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For the Technically Minded

Why This Agent Beats General "On-Line" Searching

The AI Agent has been given the latest golf Definitions and their Clarifications, Local Rules Procedures, Rules of Golf, and their official Clarifications. This local vector dataset acts as a hard filter against outside noise:

- **Immunity to Hallucinated Precedents:** The R&A and USGA update rules and issue official clarifications quarterly (January, April, July, and October). General online searches often crawl outdated historical rule variations (like old 2019 text or archived forums). This dataset ensures exclusive reliance on current governing principles.
 - **Protection Against Forum Myths:** Public threads feature confident but incorrect interpretations (p. 3). This database strictly blocks conversational forum opinions.
 - **Precision Under Strict Logic Frameworks:** Subtle phrasing variations matter immensely in golf (e.g., the exact distinction between Rule 16.1a denying relief if a tree blocks a stroke versus general abnormal course conditions). By embedding a maximum 10-chunk retrieval window and a broad similarity threshold, we force the LLM agent to evaluate the entire overarching rule section and its inline clarifications simultaneously, leaving zero semantic blind spots."
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The True Baseline: 2026 Rules Modernisation

To completely match the precision of an un-restricted model without risking hallucinations, the database fully accounts for the **2026 Rules Modernisation and Official Clarification updates**. The agent performs flawlessly because its local vector chunks explicitly feature these core revisions:

- **Unknowingly Moved Balls:** The penalty for a ball that accidentally moves outside the putting green without the player's knowledge has dropped from two strokes to one stroke.
- **Other Players' Pitch Marks:** The updated **Model Local Rule F-2.3** allows free relief from an unrepaired pitch mark in areas cut to fairway height or lower, even if that pitch mark was created by a different player's stroke.
- **Scorecard Length Preferred Lies:** Adjustments to preferred lies in adverse conditions now restrict the lifting, cleaning, and placing relief area to exactly **one scorecard length** rather than a full club length.
- **Internal Out-of-Bounds:** New boundaries stipulate that internal white stakes defining out-of-bounds on doglegs or adjacent holes apply **exclusively to tee shots**, vanishing for any subsequent recovery shots.

 **Cost Alert:** Please use the Agent sparingly. Detailed question sessions cost **ten pence a minute**. If a club has 1,000 members and everyone decides to call, a hundred pounds in fees can be incurred easily.



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Appendix - R & A's Advanced Quiz Results - 6th July 2026

Testing with System Prompt Version 5.8

These are the results of the R&A's 'Advanced Quiz'. The 'Voice Agent' was asked the questions without any answer options being provided.

The questions shown in **red** are those where the Agent gave an incorrect answer. The reason it failed is that AI Voice Agents are explicitly designed to be used in real-world, first-person situations. If questions are too abstract or "quizzzy", they can undermine how the Agent was designed to navigate the rules database. Even though an incorrect answer was initially returned, re-framing the exact same scenario as a real-world situation ensured the Agent did its job perfectly and returned the correct ruling.

1. User

After searching for two minutes a player finds what they believe to be another player's ball, so they continue to search for their ball. After the three-minute search time ends, it is then discovered that the ball the player found and believed to be another player's ball was in fact the player's ball. What is the ruling?

Agent

The ball is lost and the player must take stroke-and-distance relief under Rule 18.2 B. Under Rule 18.2 A 1 and the Definition of Lost, the ball must be found and identified as the player's ball within the three-minute search time; because the player did not identify that ball as theirs within three minutes, the ball became lost when the three minutes expired, and discovering afterwards that it was their ball does not change that status.

2. User

The position of a player's body is part of the stance.

Agent

That statement is true. According to the Definition of Stance and the Definition of Conditions Affecting the Stroke, a player's stance includes both where the feet are placed and the entire area that might reasonably affect how and where the player's body is positioned in preparing for and making a stroke.

3. User

In match play, a player moves a leaf lying close to their ball in a penalty area and in doing so causes their ball to move. What is the ruling?

Agent

The ball must be replaced on its original spot and the player gets one penalty stroke. In a penalty area, a leaf is a loose impediment and the ball is in play, so when the player moved the leaf and caused their ball to move, that is a breach of Rule 9.4 B (moving their ball while removing a loose impediment); none of the exceptions in Rule 9.4 B or Rule 7.4 apply, so the one-stroke penalty stands and the ball must be replaced.

4. User

A player's ball lies just off the putting green. There is sand on the putting green between the ball and the hole that the player wishes to remove. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player is allowed to remove the sand from the putting green without penalty. Under Rule 13.1 C 1 and Rule 8.1 B 10, sand and loose soil may always be removed from the putting green, even when the ball lies off the green, so the player may clear that sand before playing.



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5. User

In a match, player B has completed the hole in 5 strokes. Player A, who has a putt for a 5, asks B's what their score was for the hole. B mistakenly states that they holed out in 4 strokes. Player A picks up their ball without marking its position. Player B then corrects their mistake. What is the ruling?

Agent

Player B loses the hole. By wrongly stating a score of 4 instead of 5 and only correcting it after Player A lifted their ball, B breached Rule 3.2 D 1; that wrong information caused A to lift their ball, but under the "root infraction" priority B gets the loss-of-hole penalty and A gets no penalty for lifting without marking.

6. User

Player B's ball was lying badly in deep rough. Player A said to player B: "You have no shot at all. If I were you, I would declare the ball unplayable." What is the ruling?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

There is no penalty to either player and play continues. Under Rule 10.2 A and Rule 19.1, a player is allowed to give advice and suggest options such as declaring a ball unplayable, and only the player themselves may decide whether to take unplayable ball relief.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The AI Voice Agent is strictly optimized for real-world, on-course scenarios spoken by actual competitors in the first person. Abstract, third-person textbook syntax (using "Player A" and "Player B") lacks the physical nouns and conversational anchors the system uses to navigate the database. When phrased as a real-world scenario, the agent immediately accesses the correct rule and delivers the proper penalty. A real-world question would sound like:

User - Re-framed Question

I am playing in a stroke-play competition and a fellow-competitor's ball was lying terribly in deep rough. I looked at it and told him, 'You have no shot at all. If I were you, I would declare the ball unplayable.' Do I get a penalty for saying this?

Agent

You do get a penalty: that is advice and is not allowed between competitors in stroke play. Under Rule 10.2 a, giving advice like recommending that they declare the ball unplayable is a two-stroke penalty in stroke play.

7. User

A player's ball came to rest beside a raised turf area which interferes with their swing. The turf is raised due to an underground pipe which can be seen coming out of the ground a few feet away. The player may take free relief under Rule 16.1.

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

That statement is correct: the player may take free relief under Rule 16.1. The raised turf caused by the underground pipe is part of an immovable obstruction, which is an abnormal course condition, so with interference for the swing and the ball in the general area, the player is entitled to free relief using the nearest point of complete relief under Rule 16.1.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The interaction with the Agent isn't ideal. Agents are desperate to please when contacted. As the User used a very specific rule number, Rule 16.1, the agent attached a great deal of focus on that rule and that the statement 'The player may take free relief under Rule 16.1' used by the User suggested they really wanted 'free relief', so the Agent provided an answer so the User could get 'free relief'. Agents try to be too nice so you must be careful how you handle them.



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The 'Voice Agent' on the website is designed to be accessed by team members playing for a club, and for access while they are playing. This should result in real world questions and not 'quiz' questions. So, in the real world, this question would sound like:

User - Re-framed Question

My ball is resting right next to a patch of raised turf. The turf is raised up because of an underground water pipe that I can see sticking out of the ground a few yards away. The raised turf completely messes up my swing. Am I allowed to take free relief from this?

Agent

You are allowed free relief, but only if that raised turf itself is treated as an abnormal course condition such as ground under repair. Under Rule 16.1 A and 16.1 B, you get free relief from an animal hole, ground under repair, temporary water, or an immovable obstruction when that condition actually interferes with your lie, stance, or area of intended swing. The fact that an underground pipe is causing the turf to bulge does not, by itself, make the bulge an immovable obstruction; the obstruction is the pipe, not the soil above it. So: if the Committee or local rules define that raised area as ground under repair (or as part of an immovable obstruction), you may take free relief in the general area using nearest point of complete relief and one club length, no nearer the hole, under Rule 16.1 B. If it is just naturally raised turf with no such designation, there is no free relief and you must either play it as it lies or take unplayable ball relief under Rule 19.

8. User

Both players in a match due to start at 9.00am arrive late to the starting point. Player A arrives at 9.01am and Player B arrives at 9.03am. What is the ruling?

Agent

The first hole is tied and the match starts on the second hole with the match all square. Under Rule 5.3 A Exception 1 and Clarification 5.3a/5, both players arrived at the starting point ready to play no more than five minutes late, so each gets a loss-of-hole penalty; these offset, so the result of the first hole is a tie and there is no further penalty for either player.

9. User

In stroke play, a player plays a left-handed stroke with the back of the head of a right-handed club. What is the ruling?

Agent

The stroke counts and there is no penalty. Using the back of the head of a conforming right-handed club to make a left-handed stroke is allowed; a stroke is simply the forward movement of the club made to strike the ball under the Definition of Stroke, and the Rules do not require the club to be used in its "intended" orientation.

10. User

A ball played from the putting green is seen to strike a worm before being holed. What is the ruling?

Agent

The ball is holed with no penalty and the stroke counts. A worm is an animal and therefore an outside influence; under Rule 11.1 A and Rule 11.1 B 2, when a ball played from the putting green accidentally hits an outside influence and then is holed, the stroke stands and the ball is treated as holed from where it came to rest.

11. User



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In stroke play, a player playing from the teeing area misses the ball completely. They push the tee farther into the ground and then play the ball. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player gets no penalty and both strokes count; they have played two strokes. After the missed stroke, the ball is in play in the teeing area under Rule 6.2 B 6, and Rule 8.1 B 8 and Clarification 8.1b/4 allow the player to alter the surface of the ground in the teeing area, including pushing the tee farther into the ground, before making the next stroke.

12. User

In match play, a player marks the position of their ball on the putting green, lifts the ball and sets it aside. By mistake, they putt the ball from the spot where it was aside. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player gets the general penalty (loss of hole) for playing from a wrong place. Because the stroke was made from the wrong spot on the putting green (not where the ball was marked and lifted), this is playing from a wrong place under Rule 14.7, and in match play the penalty is loss of hole.

13. User

During a round, a player runs out of balls. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player is disqualified unless they can get another conforming ball without unreasonably delaying play. Under Rule 4.2 and Rule 5.6 A, you must always play a conforming ball; if you have none left and cannot promptly obtain one, you cannot continue the round and are disqualified.

14. User

In stroke play, player A looks into player B's bag without touching or moving anything to see which club B used for their last stroke. What is the ruling?

Agent

There is no penalty; this is allowed. Looking into another player's bag without touching or moving anything is not considered asking for or giving advice under Rule 10.2 A, so player A may do this in stroke play.

15. User

If the wall of a bunker consists of soil, the wall is part of the bunker.

Agent

That statement is false. Under the Definition of Bunker, a lip, wall or face made of soil or grass at the edge of the prepared sand is specifically not part of the bunker; it is part of the general area.

16. User

In stroke play, player A concedes player B's short putt and knocks the ball away. Player B lifts their ball and plays from the next tee. What is the ruling?

Agent

Player B is disqualified. Concessions are only allowed in match play, not stroke play. In stroke play, A's "concession" and knocking B's ball away have no effect; B has failed to hole out under Rule 3.3 C and, having teed off the next hole without correcting this, is disqualified.



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17. User

A player searches for their ball and thinks it may have been lifted by a spectator but isn't sure. After a three-minute search, and while the player walks back to the tee, a spectator admits that he had picked up the ball. What is the ruling?

Agent

The ball is lost and the player must take stroke-and-distance relief. Because it was not known or virtually certain within the three-minute search time that an outside influence had picked up the ball, once the three minutes expired the ball was lost under Rule 18.2 B; learning afterwards that a spectator lifted it does not change this, as clarified in Known or Virtually Certain slash 3.

18. User

In match play, a player observes a breach of the Rules by his opponent but decides not to act on it. What is the ruling?

Agent

There is no penalty and the match continues as played, provided there was no agreement to ignore the breach. Under Rule 3.2 D and Clarification 3.2d(4)/1, a player may choose on their own not to act on an opponent's breach; only if both players agree together to ignore a breach or a known penalty are they both disqualified under Rule 1.3 B.



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Other 'Testing(Hard)' Questions:

The following are the results of 'Soak Testing' the 'Voice Agent' with additional complex questions regarding the rules.

The Questions shown in red are where the Agent failed to return a correct answer, mainly due to the 'quiz' nature, over supply of information or unclear timeline.

In all cases, clarifying/simplifying the question gave the correct result.

You must ask questions according to the world the Agent lives in which is conversational.

User

In a match between players A and B, A has played 3 strokes and B has holed out for 4. Player A putts and their ball apparently comes to rest, but is overhanging the hole. After only five seconds, player B picks up A's ball to return it to them. What is the ruling?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

Player A is treated as having holed out in 3 strokes and wins the hole, with no penalty to either player. Under Rule 13.3 A, A is entitled to a reasonable time to reach the hole plus ten seconds for an overhanging ball; under Rule 13.3 B, because the opponent in match play deliberately lifted A's ball overhanging the hole before that waiting time ended, A's ball is treated as holed with the last stroke (the putt that left it overhanging).

User - Re-framed Question (Best not to use 'Players A and B' as Agent is confused)

I'm playing in a match, and my opponent has holed out for 4. I've just putted for a four, but my ball was left overhanging the hole. My opponent picked up my ball after five seconds and gave it to me. What is the ruling.

Agent

Your ball is treated as holed in 4, the same as your opponent, and there's no penalty to either of you. Under Rule 13.3 B, because your ball was overhanging and your opponent lifted it before the full waiting time had expired, in match play you are treated as having holed out with the last stroke that left it on the lip.

User

In match play, a player mistakenly picks up their ball-marker believing they have won a hole. What is the ruling?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

The player gets one penalty stroke for lifting their ball or ball-marker in play without a valid reason, and the ball must be replaced before they continue. Under Rule 9.7 B and Rule 14.1, a deliberate lift based on a mistaken belief that the hole is over is still a player action in breach of the Rules, and there's no free exemption just because they thought they had won the hole.

User - Re-framed Question (Use first person)

I'm playing a match and mistakenly picked up my ball-marker believing I had won the hole. What is the ruling?

Agent

You get one penalty stroke and must replace the ball-marker on its spot, then replace your ball and continue play. Under Rule 9.7 B and Rule 14.2, deliberately lifting your ball-marker when the hole is not actually over is a breach, even though you mistakenly thought you had won the hole.

User



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A player realises that their putter shaft became bent when they slammed it into the ground after scoring an 8 on the previous hole. They want to continue to use the club with the bent shaft. What is the ruling?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

The player is not allowed to continue using that putter; it has become non-conforming through abuse, so it must not be used for the rest of the round. Under Rule 4.1 A and the related Clarification, when a club is damaged by abuse (like slamming it into the ground), it is treated as non-conforming, and the player may not make a stroke with it again.

User - Re-framed Question (Use first person)

If I damage a club during a round by slamming it on the ground in bad temper, can I carry on using it.

Agent

Yes, you can keep using it for the rest of that round. Under Rule 4.1 A 2, any club damaged during the round, even by abuse like slamming it, is still treated as conforming so you may continue to make strokes with it, but you're not allowed to repair or replace it unless the Committee has a Model Local Rule G 9 that further restricts replacement.

User

In foursomes match play, a player whose turn it is to play plays first from the tee. Their partner then plays from the tee as though it is a four-ball competition. What is the ruling?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

The side loses the hole. Under Rule 22.3 and its Clarification 22.3 slash 2, when both partners tee off in foursomes you first determine whose turn it actually was: - If it was the first player's turn, the second tee shot becomes the ball in play under stroke and distance, the side lies 3 (including one penalty), and it is now the first player's turn to play next. - If it was the second player's turn, the first player has played in the wrong order, so in match play the side gets the general penalty of loss of hole.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The Agent does give a comprehensive answer so you can work out if there is a penalty but the Agent's answer of 'The side loses the hole' is not correct. This is for two reasons; the Agent got a bit lost because of the phrase 'as though it is a four-ball competition' and the question wasn't in the first person.

User - Re-framed Question (Use first person)

I'm playing a foursomes match, and both my opponents have just teed off before me. Is there a penalty for this.

Agent

There's no penalty just for both of them teeing off before you in foursomes, but only one of them was actually allowed to play that shot. Under Rule 22.3 and Rule 6.4 A, you and your partner must alternate, and so must your opponents; if the wrong opponent played from the tee, their side gets the general penalty, and they must correct it by having the right partner play from where the first wrong-order stroke was made.

This answer is 'correct' as it identifies 'General Penalty', so loss of hole in matchplay so 'and they must correct it by having the right partner play from where the first wrong-order stroke was made' is a little redundant.

If you ask the following:

User

I'm playing a foursomes match, and both my opponents have just teed off before me. What is the ruling.

Agent



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The side that played in the wrong order gets the general penalty for Foursomes, but which player's ball is in play depends on whose turn it actually was. Under Rule 22.3 and Clarification 22.3 slash 2:

- If it was Player A's turn to tee off, then Player B's ball is the ball in play under stroke and distance, their side has 3 strokes (including 1 penalty), and it's now Player A's turn.
- If it was Player B's turn to tee off, their side gets the general penalty for playing in the wrong order when Player A played first; in stroke play they add 2 penalty strokes and Player B's ball is in play with the side lying 3, in match play they lose the hole.

You get a comprehensive answer.

User

As a player was searching in a pile of leaves, they accidentally kicked and moved their ball as well as a number of the leaves around the ball. The player estimated where the ball originally lay and replaced it on that spot but did not replace the leaves before making their next stroke. What is the ruling?

Agent

There is no penalty, and the ball was correctly replaced and played. Under Rule 7.4 and Clarification 7.4 slash 1, when a ball is accidentally moved during a fair search the player must replace it on its original or estimated spot, but is not required to put loose impediments like leaves back in their original position, even if the ball had been under them.

User

A substituted ball that was dropped or replaced in a wrong way is not considered to be "In Play".

Agent

That statement is not correct under the Rules. Once you substitute another ball and put it on the course with the intent for it to be in play, it is in play even if it was dropped, placed or replaced in a wrong way or in a wrong place. This is stated in the Definition of Substitute, the Definition of In Play, Rule 6.3 B 2 and Rule 14.4. You may be able to correct the mistake without penalty, but only if you do so before making a stroke at that substituted ball, under Rule 14.5 A.

User

In a match, a player's ball came to rest beside some steps attached to a boundary fence. The steps interfered with the player's swing, so they took free relief before playing their next stroke. What is the ruling?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

The player gets the general penalty for taking free relief; they were not entitled to it. The steps are part of the boundary fence, which is a boundary object, not an immovable obstruction or other abnormal course condition, so there is no free relief under Rule 16.1 and the ball must be played as it lies or treated as unplayable.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The Agent was given too much information. The Agent has a limited search window so providing excessive information will force the Agent to check multiple items, this will fill its attention span and just run out of space.

User - Re-framed Question (Use first person and keep to the point)

I'm playing a match and my swing is impeded by some steps attached to a boundary fence. What is the ruling?

Agent

The steps are an obstruction and you're allowed free relief from them, but not from the boundary fence itself. Under the Definitions of Boundary Object and Obstruction, steps attached to a boundary fence are not part of the boundary object, so they're treated as an immovable obstruction. You may take free



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relief from the steps under Rule 16.1, finding your nearest point of complete relief from the steps only, and dropping within one club length no nearer the hole, knowing that the nearest point could be in a worse spot such as heavier rough or behind a tree.

User

The player's second shot lands in the greenside bunker. The player hits the ball out of the bunker and it comes to rest just short of the green. The player removes the sand that landed both on the green and off the green using a towel as it was on their line of play. What is the ruling in stroke play?

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

The player gets a two-stroke general penalty. Under Rule 8.1 B and its interpretation, the player is allowed to remove sand on the putting green, but may not remove sand off the green when that improves conditions affecting the stroke such as the line of play, so wiping away the sand off the green is a breach of Rule 8.1 A.

User

In stroke play, a player bends some long grass out of the way to get a clear view of their ball in the rough. They then play their next stroke. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player gets the general penalty of two strokes. Under Rule 8.1 A and Clarification 7.1a/1, deliberately bending long grass just to get a clear view of the ball (not as part of a reasonable search) is not a fair search action, so if it improves the conditions affecting the stroke and the player then plays, it is a breach of Rule 8.1a.

User

A player plays their second shot, searches for the ball briefly and then goes back and drops another ball under penalty of stroke and distance. Before the player can play the dropped ball, the player's original ball is found within three minutes of when the player first started searching for it. What is the ruling?

Agent

The dropped ball is the ball in play under stroke and distance, and the original ball must not be played. Under Rule 18.1 and its clarification, once you have dropped a ball to take stroke-and-distance relief from a shot played from the general area, that dropped ball is in play immediately; finding the original within three minutes does not change this, and if you were to play the original ball you would be playing a wrong ball.

User

A player plays their tee shot, searches for the ball briefly and then goes back and tees another ball as a provisional ball. Before the player can play the provisional ball, the player's original ball is found within three minutes of when the player first started searching for it. What is the ruling?

Agent

The original ball is still the ball in play and the teed "provisional" must be abandoned. Because the original was found within three minutes, Rule 18.3 A and the Clarification 18.3a/2 say the player must continue with the original ball and may not now play the provisional ball.



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User

In stroke play, a player waiting to play to the green drops a ball on the fairway and hit two practice putts with their putter. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player gets the general penalty, two penalty strokes, for making practice strokes while playing a hole in breach of Rule 5.5 A, because hitting those two putts at a ball on the fairway is practice during play of the hole.

User

In stroke play, a player has interference to their stance from an immovable obstruction. They determine their nearest point of complete relief using a five iron (as that is the club he would have used had the immovable obstruction not been there) and drop the ball within one club-length of that point, no nearer the hole. The ball settles down in the rough, so the player changes club and plays the ball out onto the fairway with a sand wedge. What is the ruling?

Agent

The relief and the stroke both stand – there is no penalty. Under Rule 16.1 B, you choose your nearest point of complete relief using the club, stance, and swing you would have used if the obstruction weren't there, and you must drop within one club-length of that point, no nearer the hole. Once the ball has been dropped in the correct relief area and comes to rest in it, the ball is in play and you're then free to choose any club, stance, or direction of play for your next stroke, including changing to a sand wedge and playing onto the fairway.

User

A player takes lateral relief from a red penalty area by correctly dropping a ball in the two club-length relief area. While the player is assessing their next shot, a gust of wind blows the ball back into the penalty area. What is the ruling?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

The ball must be re-dropped without penalty, and it must come to rest in the proper lateral relief area outside the penalty area. Under Rule 14.3 C and Rule 17.1 D 3, a dropped ball that is moved by natural forces before it comes to rest in the relief area has not yet been put back into play, so you simply drop again in the same relief area.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The Agent did its best to work out what happened and decided the ball wasn't at rest when the wind blew it due to all the information it was given, and not given. So it determined the correct procedure to take following that.

User - Re-framed Question (Use first person and keep to the point)

I have just dropped my ball and was waiting to play when a gust of wind blew the ball into a ditch. What is the ruling.

Agent

The ball must be replaced on its original spot with no penalty, and that spot is still your relief spot, not the ditch. Under Rule 9.3 Exception 2, when a ball that has been dropped and has come to rest is then moved by natural forces into another area of the course, you must replace it on the spot where it lay before the wind moved it.



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User

I'm waiting to play my next shot when a gust of wind blows my ball into a ditch. What is the ruling.

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

The ball was moved by natural forces, so there's no penalty and the ball is now in the ditch and must be played from there. Under Rule 9.3, when wind moves a ball at rest (and no special exception applies, like a replaced ball on the putting green or a recently dropped ball moving to another area), you have to play it from its new spot or take unplayable ball relief under Rule 19.

User

A player finds her ball lying next to a loose impediment in a bunker. She decides to move the apple, but in doing so accidentally causes her ball to move. She places her ball back on its original spot and plays it from there. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player gets one penalty stroke and must play the ball from its original spot, which she did correctly. Under Rule 15.1 B and Rule 9.4 B, if your ball at rest (not on the teeing area or putting green) is moved when you remove a loose impediment, you must replace it and add one penalty stroke.

User

A player finds her ball lying next to a loose impediment on the green. She decides to move the twig, but in doing so accidentally causes her ball to move. She places her ball back on its original spot and plays it from there. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player gets no penalty, and the ball was correctly replaced and played. On the putting green, if a ball is moved when removing a loose impediment, it must be replaced but there is no penalty, by exception to Rule 9.4 B as referenced in Rule 15.1 B and Rule 13.1 D.

User

In stroke play, a marker knowingly certifies a scorecard that contains a lower score than the player actually made on a hole. What is the penalty?

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

The player is disqualified and the marker is disqualified. Under Rule 3.3 B 3 a wrong lower score means disqualification for the player, and under Rule 1.2 A a marker who knowingly certifies a wrong score should also be disqualified.

User

While playing the 4th hole, a player realizes they have 15 clubs in their bag. They immediately declare the excess club out of play to their opponent. The player discovered this after making their tee shot on the 1st hole. What is the maximum penalty applied in stroke play?

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

The player gets four penalty strokes in total. Under Rule 4.1 B, it's two penalty strokes for each hole where the breach occurred, with a maximum of four strokes in the round.



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User

A player makes a stroke at their ball in a yellow penalty area. The ball fails to exit the penalty area. The player decides they want to take back-on-the-line relief outside the penalty area. How many penalty strokes are accumulated from the time the ball entered the penalty area?

Agent

The player has a total of 2 penalty strokes from the time the ball first entered the yellow penalty area. Under Rule 17.2 A and 17.1 D, the stroke played from inside the penalty area counts as a normal stroke, and when the player then takes back-on-the-line relief outside the penalty area that adds one penalty stroke (there is no extra penalty just because the previous stroke was also from inside the penalty area).

Reason for Incorrect(ish) Answer

The Agent did identify the one penalty stroke correctly, but it answered two. The reason it did this is because the Agent doesn't play golf. It matched the stroke in the penalty area as a penalty stroke, like a stroke in a bunker is a bunker stroke or a stroke on a fairway is a fairway stroke. So don't be too hard on the Agent.

User

A player hits a tee shot into a thick forest. They state, "I might hit another one just in case," and play a second ball. They find the original ball in bounds within 3 minutes of searching. What is the status of the original ball?

Agent

The original ball is still the ball in play, and the second ball must be abandoned. Saying "I might hit another one just in case" is a valid announcement of a provisional under Rule 18.3 B, and since the original was found in bounds within three minutes and the provisional was not played from nearer the hole than the estimated spot of the original, Rule 18.3 C says you must continue with the original ball.

User

My ball is in a narrow ditch designated as a yellow penalty area. I play the ball twice while in the ditch and only manage to move it down the ditch. Can I take an unplayable lie or back in line relief from where my ball currently lies.

Agent

You cannot take unplayable ball relief from that spot because your ball is still in a penalty area, and Rule 19.1 says unplayable relief is not allowed in penalty areas. Your only options now are either to keep playing the ball as it lies in the ditch under Rule 17.1 B, or take penalty relief under Rule 17.1 D for a yellow penalty area, using the point where the ball last crossed into that ditch as your reference point.

User

My ball is near the edge of the green and there is a sprinkler three feet in front of my ball directly on my line to the hole. Do I get free relief because the sprinkler is on my line.

Agent

You do not get free relief just because a sprinkler head is on your line to the hole. Under Rule 16.1, an immovable obstruction only gives free relief when it interferes with your lie, stance, or area of intended swing, not simply your line of play, unless your Committee has adopted a special Local Rule like F 5 for obstructions near greens.



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User

I teed off and my ball ended in deep rough. As I thought I might not be able to find it I played a provisional ball which ended up near the first ball that I teed off with. I searched for my balls in the rough and found a ball. Each of the balls I played from the tee were identical and I had not marked either of them. Is there a rule that covers this situation, and if there is, what number would my next stroke be.

Agent

Your provisional ball is now the ball in play under penalty of stroke and distance, and your next stroke will be stroke number 4. Rule 18.3 C 2 says that if the original and provisional are identical and you can't tell which is which, and both balls are found on the course, you must choose one ball to treat as the provisional (now in play) and the other as the original (now out of play). Since you played two tee shots, that's 1 stroke for the original, plus 1 penalty stroke and 1 stroke for playing the provisional from the tee. Your next shot from where you found the ball is stroke number 4.

User

During stroke play, a player completes a hole but is unsure if they breached a rule. They tee off on the next hole without mentioning the issue to anyone. Later, before turning in their scorecard, they ask the Committee for a ruling. What is the outcome?

Agent

The ruling is given and their score is adjusted if needed; there's no automatic penalty just for waiting until later in the round. Under Rule 20.1 C 1 and 20.1 C 2, a player should raise rules issues with the Committee before returning their scorecard, which this player did, so the Committee will decide the correct score for that earlier hole based on the facts and any applicable penalties.

User

I'm playing a hole that is a dog leg left. There are white posts either side of the fairway at the dog left that show out of bounds past these posts. If I play a tee shot the finishes on the green, is the ball out of bounds.

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

The ball is only out of bounds if it comes to rest beyond the out-of-bounds line, not just because it crossed it in the air. Under the Purpose for Model Local Rule A-4, a Local Rule saying a ball is out of bounds merely for crossing a boundary (even if it re-crosses and finishes back on the course) is not authorized, so if your tee shot flies over that internal O-B and then comes to rest on the green in bounds, the ball is in play.

Reason for Vague Answer

One of the few occasions when the Agent doesn't have enough information to decide what to do. As the User hasn't said what the out of bounds applies to, and as the Agent wants to please, it just reports a general internal out of bounds clarification and that allows the User's ball to be in bounds.

User - Re-framed Question

There is an internal out of bounds on the dog leg I am playing. How do I know where the out of bounds area is.

Agent

The out of bounds area is exactly wherever the Local Rule says it is, using those white posts as the boundary. Under Model Local Rule A-4.1, the stakes define the whole internal area that is out of bounds during play of that hole, and your ball is out of bounds only if it comes to rest beyond the boundary line formed by those stakes. Under Model Local Rule A-4.2, the same stakes may define an out of bounds area that applies only to strokes played from the teeing area, so you need to read the



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scorecard or local rules notice to see whether your club is using A-4.1 or A-4.2 and how they've worded it.

User

A player thinks their ball is unplayable in a bush. They choose to take lateral relief. Without dropping a ball, they estimate the relief area, place a substituted ball on the fairway, and play it. What is the ruling?

Agent - **Answers Incorrectly**

The player has played from a wrong place and gets the general penalty. Under Rule 19.2 C, unplayable lateral relief must be taken by dropping (not placing) in the two club length relief area, so placing a substituted ball on the fairway means the ball was put in play from a wrong place under Rule 14.7 and the general penalty applies (loss of hole in match play, two strokes in stroke play).

Reason for Incorrect Answer

1. The Multi-Step Timeline of the Question

In the real-world scenario, the golfer executed two entirely separate, consecutive choices that each carry independent consequences [Rule 1.3c(4)]:

- **Action A (The Decision):** The player decides to take unplayable lateral relief. (This instantly triggers **1 penalty stroke** under Rule 19.2c [Rule 19.2c]). [1]
- **Action B (The Execution):** Instead of measuring and dropping a ball in the correct zone, they estimate an area and *place* a substituted ball on the fairway. They then play it. (This instantly triggers **2 penalty strokes / General Penalty** for playing from a wrong place under Rule 14.7a [Rule 14.7a]).

2. How the Agent Smashed the Timeline Together

When the agent reads the phrase "*place a substituted ball on the fairway, and play it,*" it looks for a single text block in its knowledge database that matches those exact vocabulary tokens [Rule 14.7a]. Because it operates on soft semantic patterns rather than chronological rules arithmetic, it collapses the timeline [Rule 1.3c(4)]:

1. It hits the high-weight tokens "**place on fairway**" and "**play it.**"
2. It correctly identifies this single moment as a **Wrong Place** breach under Rule 14.7a [Rule 14.7a].
3. It prints out the penalty for *only* that final step: **2 penalty strokes** (or loss of hole) [Rule 14.7a].

Because Action A (the 1-stroke intent to take unplayable relief) happened earlier in the sentence, the agent treats it as background narrative ("the fluff") rather than a distinct mathematical transaction [Rule 19.2]. It fails to look backward in time to add that 1 stroke to the 2 strokes [Rule 1.3c(4)]. [1]

Why a Rephrased Question Fixes the Math

When the rewrote question included the playing partners telling you to correct it and moving to back-on-the-line relief, the Agent was stopped in its tracks: the Agent was **forced** on a strict chronological timeline into the text block [Rule 1.3c(4)].

By asking "*How many penalty strokes did I get **before** playing the back in line relief stroke,*" it explicitly broke the scenario into distinct historical phases. It forced the AI's logic engine to pause, log the 1 stroke from the first unplayable decision, add the 2 strokes for the serious wrong-place correction breach, and cleanly print out **3 penalty strokes** [Rule 1.3c(4)].

It proves that when a question lacks a strict timeline anchor, the machine will always default to a lazy keyword match of the final physical action it sees.

User - Re-framed Question

My ball is unplayable in a bush but I couldn't reach it. I decided to just place the ball on the fairway. I then played the ball. My playing partners said I had broken the rules and said I should correct my



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mistake. I decided to take back in line relief from where I could see my original ball in the bush. How many penalty strokes did I get before playing the back in line relief stroke.

Agent

You had 3 penalty strokes before playing the back-on-the-line stroke.

1) First, when you “just placed the ball on the fairway” and played it without using any of the Rule 19.2 relief options, you played from a wrong place, which is the general penalty: 2 strokes under Rule 14.7 A.

2) Then, when you corrected and took proper back-on-the-line unplayable relief from the bush, that adds the normal 1-stroke unplayable penalty under Rule 19.2. So, total before the back-on-the-line stroke: 2 (general penalty for wrong place) + 1 (unplayable) = 3 penalty strokes.

User

In stroke play, a player swings at and misses a wrong ball. What is the ruling?

Agent

The player gets the general penalty of two strokes for making a stroke at a wrong ball, but the missed swing itself does not count in their score. Under the Definition of Stroke and Rule 6.3c, a swing-and-miss at a wrong ball is still a stroke at a wrong ball, so only the two-stroke penalty is added and the player must then correct the mistake by playing the right ball.

User

I found a ball in the rough that I thought was mine. I tried to hit it and missed completely. I found out later the ball wasn't mine. What is the ruling?

Agent

You’ve played a wrong ball, and that stroke still counts as a stroke in terms of effort but does not count toward your score with your real ball. In match play, under Rule 6.3c, it’s loss of hole for playing a wrong ball. In stroke play, it’s a two-stroke penalty, and you must correct by finding and playing your original ball (or proceeding under stroke-and-distance if it’s lost or out of bounds); the stroke at the wrong ball and anything after it with that wrong ball do not count in your score.

User

Do I have to tell my playing partners I'm going to lift my ball to identify it.

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

You no longer have to announce that you’re going to lift your ball to identify it.

Under Rule 7.3, you may lift to identify without telling anyone, but you must first mark the spot and you may only clean it as much as needed to identify it (except on the putting green, where you can clean it fully). If you fail to mark, or you clean it more than allowed, it’s one penalty stroke.

User

I am in a stroke play competition, and I picked up my ball to identify it. My fellow competitor said I should have marked it first. I then fully cleaned my ball and replaced it on its original spot. Do I really get a penalty for this?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

You do get a penalty, but it’s only one stroke total, not one for each thing you did.

Under Rule 7.3 and Rule 4.2 C 1, once you lift a ball to identify it, you must mark the spot first and you must not clean it more than necessary; failing to mark and fully cleaning are both breaches, but Clarification 1.3 C 4 slash 2 says that when you commit multiple related breaches without an



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intervening event, you only get a single penalty. So in your case it's one penalty stroke, and your ball was correctly replaced on its original spot and stays in play.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The Agent will never decipher this type of intervening event question. The rules explicitly give the example of being spoken to is an intervening event, but if the intervening event was, how many strokes have you had, is that an intervening event or not? Just accept the golf rules aren't perfect so a logical Agent may get a very few answers incorrect.

User

My ball is in a deep bunker, but it rolled right into a massive hole dug by a rabbit. It's impossible to swing. What are my options? Do I have to drop it in the sand?

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

You do not have to play it from that rabbit hole, and you may not be limited to dropping in the sand, depending on the option you choose. Under Rule 16.1 A and B, an animal hole is an abnormal course condition, so you're entitled to free relief if a reasonable stroke toward the hole is made impossible by that hole. Your standard free-relief option is: find the nearest point of complete relief from the rabbit hole in the bunker (where a normal stroke is possible), then drop within one club-length of that point, no nearer the hole. That relief area must stay in the bunker, and the ball must come to rest there. If that still leaves you with no reasonable stroke, or you just prefer not to deal with the bunker, you can declare the ball unplayable under Rule 19.3. Then you have these options: for one penalty stroke, stroke-and-distance (go back and replay from where you last played); for one penalty stroke, back-on-the-line relief in the bunker; for one penalty stroke, lateral relief in the bunker; or for a total of two penalty strokes, back-on-the-line relief outside the bunker under Rule 19.3 B. If you are a player using a wheeled mobility device and Model Local Rule M-4 or Rule 25.4 N is in effect, there may be additional or reduced-penalty relief options, including back-on-the-line relief outside the bunker for only one penalty stroke.

User

The bunker is completely flooded with water. There isn't a single dry spot of sand to drop a ball. Can I drop it outside the bunker on the grass without a penalty?

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

No, not under the normal Rules alone; free relief without penalty must stay in the bunker. Under Rule 16.1 C, if your ball is in a bunker and the abnormal condition (temporary water) gives you interference, your free relief area has to be in that bunker, even if it means using the point of maximum available relief in water. To drop outside the bunker on the grass, you need either: one penalty stroke using back-on-the-line relief under Rule 16.1 C 2, or your Committee must have adopted Model Local Rule F-16 for that specific bunker, which treats it as ground under repair in the general area and then allows free relief outside.



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User

My ball is buried face-deep in a bunker wall and I can't hit it. I want to escape this sand trap entirely. How many penalty strokes will it cost me to drop outside the bunker?

Knowledge Base Retrieval

Agent

It will cost you two penalty strokes to get relief outside that bunker. Under Rule 19.3 B, when your ball is in a bunker and unplayable, you can take back-on-the-line relief outside the bunker for a total of two penalty strokes.

User

I am in a stroke play competition and I picked up my ball to identify it. My fellow competitor spoke to me and said I should have marked it first. After he finished I then fully cleaned my ball to identify it and replaced it on its original spot. Do I really get a penalty for this?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

You do get a single one-stroke penalty here.

Under Rule 7.3, you must mark the spot before lifting to identify, and under Rule 14.1 C you're only allowed to clean the ball as much as needed to identify it (except on the putting green). Because you lifted without marking and then fully cleaned it when that wasn't allowed, you've breached 7.3 and 14.1 C as a single continuous action with no intervening event, so by Clarification 1.3 C 4 line 2 you only get one penalty stroke, not two.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The Agent couldn't spot the intervening event of being spoken to.

User

I am in a stroke play competition and I picked up my ball to identify it. My fellow competitor said I should have marked it first. I then fully cleaned my ball to identify it and replaced it on its original spot. Do I really get a penalty for this?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

Yes, you do get a penalty, but it's only one stroke in total for everything you described.

Under Rule 7.3, when you lift a ball to identify it you must mark the spot first and you must not clean it more than needed to identify it. Failing to mark and over-cleaning in that same sequence is treated as a single breach with a single one-stroke penalty, not two separate penalties, because there was no intervening event between the acts.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The Agent couldn't spot the intervening event of being spoken to.

User

I am in a stroke play competition and I picked up my ball to identify it. My fellow competitor spoke to me and said I should have marked it first. I then fully cleaned my ball to identify it and replaced it on its original spot. Do I really get a penalty for this?

Agent - Answers Incorrectly

You do get a penalty, but it's only one stroke, not two.

Here's why: under Rule 7.3 and Rule 4.2 C 1, once you lift to identify, you must have marked the spot first and you're not allowed to clean the ball more than necessary to identify it. You've described two breaches (not marking before lifting, and then fully cleaning when that wasn't allowed), but they all happened in one sequence with no intervening event. Under Clarification 1.3 C 4 slash 2, that counts as a single one-stroke penalty. Then you correctly replaced the ball on its original spot, so you just add one penalty stroke to your score for that hole and play on.

Reason for Incorrect Answer

The Agent couldn't spot the intervening event of being spoken to.



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By introducing 'After that' in the question the Agent recognises a physical timeline break and gives a correct answer due to the 'Intervening Event'.

User - Re-framed Question

I picked up my ball to identify it without marking it. My fellow competitor then stopped me and spoke to me about it. After that conversation, I proceeded to fully clean the ball anyway and replaced it. Is there a penalty for this?

Agent

There are two separate issues here: not marking the spot, and cleaning during identification.

1) Not marking before lifting: Under Rule 14.1 A, lifting your ball that must be replaced without first marking its spot is one penalty stroke.

2) Cleaning while identifying: Under Rule 14.1 C and Rule 7.3, when lifting only to identify, you may clean the ball only as much as necessary to identify it. Fully cleaning it goes beyond that and is another one-stroke penalty.

So, your total is two penalty strokes for that hole (one for lifting without marking, one for over-cleaning during identification), and you must continue with the ball replaced on its original spot.

User - Re-framed Question

I picked up my ball to identify it without marking it. My fellow competitor then stopped me and spoke to me about it. After that conversation, I proceeded to fully clean the ball anyway and replaced it. Is there a penalty for this?

Agent

There is a penalty, and it's actually two separate one-stroke penalties.

Under Rule 7.3 you're allowed to lift to identify, but you must mark the ball first (Rule 14.1 A). Lifting without marking is one penalty stroke. When lifting solely to identify, you may only clean the ball as much as necessary to identify it; fully cleaning it goes beyond that, so under Rule 14.1 C you get another one-stroke penalty and must replace the ball on its spot.

User

I played my ball to the green and my ball finished three feet from the hole. When we reached the green my fellow competitor's ball was just off the green. I asked my fellow competitor if I should mark my ball. He said no. When he chipped his ball hit my ball. Is there a penalty.

Agent

There's no penalty to either of you in this situation. Under Rule 11.1 A, because his stroke was from off the putting green, there's no penalty when his ball in motion hits your ball at rest; you simply replace your ball on its original spot and both play on.

Reason for Answer

As far as the Agent is concerned the ball on the green wasn't helping, which is reasonable as nothing was said about the position of the ball in relation to the competitor's next stroke.

User

I played my ball to the green and my ball finished three feet from the hole on the green. When we reached the green my fellow competitor's ball was just off the green. I asked my fellow competitor if I should mark my ball. He said no. When he chipped his ball hit my ball. Is there a penalty.

Agent

There's no penalty to either of you.

Because his stroke was from off the putting green, Rule 11.1 A says there's no penalty when a ball in motion accidentally hits another ball at rest; you simply replace your ball on its original spot and both play on.



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Reason for Answer

As far as the Agent is concerned the ball on the green wasn't helping, which is reasonable as nothing was said about the position of the ball in relation to the competitor's next stroke.

User

I played my ball to the green and my ball finished three feet from the hole on the green. When we reached the green my fellow competitor's ball was just off the green. I asked my fellow competitor if I should mark my ball because I thought it would help him. He said no. After he chipped his ball hit my ball. Is there a penalty.

Agent

There is a penalty to both of you for agreeing to leave your ball to help him, and there is no extra penalty for the balls colliding.

By asking him to leave your ball as a "backstop" and his agreeing, you both breached Rule 15.3 A (ball on the putting green helping play), which in stroke play is the general penalty of two strokes to each player; the later contact of the balls is then covered by Rule 11.1 A with no further penalty and your ball must be replaced.

Reason for Answer

As far as the Agent is concerned the ball on the green was clearly helping.

User

I played my ball to the green and my ball finished three feet from the hole on the green. When we reached the green my fellow competitor's ball was just off the green. I asked my fellow competitor if I should mark my ball because I thought it would help him. He said no. After he chipped his ball hit my ball. Is there a penalty.

Agent

There is no penalty to either of you in this situation.

You asked if you "should" mark, he said no, but you did not agree together to leave your ball there to help his play; his ball was off the putting green, so Rule 15.3 A about a "helping" ball on the putting green is not triggered. Under Rule 11.1 A, when a ball played from off the putting green accidentally hits a ball at rest, there's no penalty; you simply replace your ball on its original spot and both play on.

Reason for Answer

The Agent suggests the word "should" doesn't clarify if the ball is helping.

User

I played my ball to the green and my ball finished three feet from the hole on the green. When we reached the green my fellow competitor's ball was just off the green. I asked my fellow competitor if I should mark my ball because I thought it would help him. He said no. After he chipped his ball hit my ball. Is there a penalty.

Agent

There is no penalty to either of you on these facts.

Even though you personally thought your ball might help him, you only asked if you "should" mark and he simply said no – that is not an agreement to leave a ball in place to help play under Rule 15.3 A, so no "backstop" penalty applies. Since his stroke was from off the putting green, when his ball in motion accidentally hit your ball at rest on the green, Rule 11.1 A says there is no penalty; you must replace your ball on its spot and both play on.

Reason for Answer

The Agent suggests the word "thought" and "should" doesn't clarify if the ball is helping.



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User

I played my ball to the green and my ball finished three feet from the hole on the green. When we reached the green my fellow competitor's ball was just off the green. I asked my fellow competitor if I should mark my ball because I could see the ball's position could help his next stroke. He said no so I left it. After he chipped his ball hit my ball. Is there a penalty.

Agent

There is a penalty to both of you in stroke play.

Because your ball was on the putting green and you specifically recognized it could help his next stroke, then asked if you should mark it and he told you to leave it, that amounts to an agreement to leave a helping ball in place. Under Rule 15.3 A and its Clarification 15.3 A slash 1, when two or more players in stroke play agree to leave a ball on the putting green to help another player and that player then makes a stroke with the ball left in place, each player who made the agreement gets the general penalty of two strokes.

When his chip then hit your ball, that contact is covered by Rule 11.1 A with no additional penalty; you must replace your ball on its original spot and both continue play, each having incurred two penalty strokes for the backstopping agreement.

Reason for Answer

The Agent clearly recognises that the ball is helping as the player said “I could see the ball's position could help his next stroke”.

Note: For these last few questions about a ‘Helping Ball’, the Agent can’t see the green, the hole and the balls, humans can, so you have to give the Agent all the relevant information, or the Agent’s answer will be based on the information you provide.

User

If I can't play a shot because there's a tree in the way and I decide to play it left handed. And now my stance is on an immovable obstruction, like a cart path. Do I get a free drop?

Agent

You only get a free drop if that left-handed stroke is a reasonable shot you’d genuinely use, not just a trick to get off the cart path. Under Rule 16.1 A 3 and Clarification 16.1 A 3 line 1, if a left-handed stroke toward the hole makes sense for your situation and the cart path then interferes with your stance, you may take free relief under Rule 16.1 B; but if you’d never reasonably play it left-handed except to claim relief, that stroke is “clearly unreasonable” and you must either play it as it lies or take unplayable ball relief.